

CASE STUDY

Homeward Unbound

INDIA TODAY tracked down two persons who had gone to Muzaffarabad for training in militant camps but chose to return in recent months. Outside his shack-like home in Chandilora village, Mohammed Ashraf Hajam hardly looked the kind of man who two decades back would have roamed around dreaming to 'liberate' the area. He is just 36 but looks at least 20 years older. At the end of a long conversation describing his journey back home, he agreed to lead me to another Kashmiri, Abdul Rashid Chopan, who also travelled with him from Muzaffarabad. Both complain of harassment by security agencies and regret about having come back. Both of them exemplify why the surrender and rehabilitation policy should not be just about getting the crossovers back, but integrating them in society.

Mohammed Ashraf Hajam, 35

Hajam was only 16 when he crossed over to POK in 1991, joined the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) and had a brief stint of military training. He took up his family business as a barber, did well, married a local girl and had three sons. "My two sons were going to a good school and had every facility at my home but my heart was always in Kashmir. I always yearned to come back," Hajam says.

He managed to get passports for his family and last December they took a flight from Islamabad to Nepal and entered India via Gorakhpur. "From Gorakhpur, we took a train to Jammu and the next day, we reached Srinagar. On December 21, we went to the police station in Tangmarg to surrender. When we told the police that we have returned from Muzaffarabad we were detained and shifted to the Joint Interrogation Centre (JIC) Humhama. After intensive questioning, we were produced before a court and released on bail. Now the police say that my family will be pushed back. It is tougher than when we crossed over to Muzaffarabad." On the surrender policy, he says: "I tell you honestly, there are many in Muzaffarabad who want to return but given what happens after one returns, you start thinking was it worth it?"

Abdul Rashid Chopan, 40

Chopan crossed over for arms training in 1990 with the JKLF and returned in December 2009 to join his uncle's shawl business before working independently. "But if you get them back from Muzaffarabad and humiliate them like we have been, then what is the policy going to achieve? There are requirements like questioning and screening, but they should not detain wives and children." Now, he too regrets having come back. "I was living a good life though I missed my parents and home. But now I feel frustrated."

by Aijaz Hussain

formed or repentant militants. Defence Minister A. K. Antony too claimed that infiltration from across the LOC had gone up. But a Home Ministry official said: "Only for some such elements, you cannot deny hundreds of other youth who want to return. There are an estimated 800 such boys who are willing to come back."

The Government had gradually been moving towards the integration of Kashmiris into the mainstream. Withdrawal of the army and Central forces from cities was already on. Over the past two years, two divisions of the army (about 30,000 personnel) had been pulled out from internal security duties. Ten battalions (about 8,000 men) of Central forces had also vacated the inhabited areas of the



PATROLLING HAS BEEN INTENSIFIED AT THE BORDER

state, making way for the state police. "The local police can anyway do better in understanding the local dialect, the problems and the nuances," said Pillai, adding: "We intend to vacate major institutions and industrial estates by June 2010. The Central forces will vacate all other places and institutions by middle of 2011."

Moreover, Chidambaram himself had made it clear that absolutely no violation of human rights by security forces would be tolerated. The latest case of BSF killing a Kashmiri teenager had also been handled firmly. It is to be hoped that such firm steps do not extract higher costs later on. ■